flood Story

Excerpts

BUILD AN ARK

Read Genesis 6:14 – 16

- In Hebrew, the description is divided into three sections
  - material
  - a few measurements regarding size
  - a few additional details
- Is the description provided by God sufficient information for building the ark?

BUILD AN ARK

Questions

- How would ***you*** build the following:
  - a boat given only exterior material, height, length and width (apart from shape)
  - some type of opening possibly related to light
  - three stories??
- What did it look like?

BUILD AN ARK

Questions

- How would ***you*** build the following:
  - a boat given only exterior material, height, length and width
  - an opening of some sort for light
  - three stories
- What is the shape?
- What is the supporting structure for the wood exterior?
- How were the interior levels to be constructed to support various animals, weights? *(Noah didn't know exactly which animals or their sizes)*
- What was to be built for human and animal excrement?
- What was the system for collecting drinking water?

BUILD AN ARK

Questions

- Why does the author give only . . .
  - exterior material,
  - height, length and width
  - an opening of some sort for light
  - possibly three stories
- Why this information but not other very necessary information?

  (compare the detailed instructions for the tabernacle)
- Why even go into this type of detail . . . insufficient at that?
- Suggestion:

The details are to communicate something symbolically!

just as God's design of creation and the tabernacle

MATERIAL

Gopher wood: What is it?

- "gopher"
  - Some English translations have "cypress" but that's speculation
  - Hebrew > *gopher*
    - i.e., nobody knows what it means
- "wood"
  - English word "wood" is misleading
  - Hebrew word for wood . . .
    - can refer to wood *(hard material)*
    - can refer to vines *(semi-hard material)*
    - can refer to flax stalks *(soft material)*
- Conclusion?
  - Some wood-***like*** material

MATERIAL

Make Rooms?

- Hebrew > *kinyim*

  "*kinym* you will make the ark"
- Original Hebrew > *knm*
  - can be two different words: "nests" or "reeds"
  - English translations gloss "nests" into "rooms"
- The "reeds" option makes more sense
  - ancient boats were made of reeds
  - "nests you will make the ark" doesn't make sense
  - Hebrew *tevah* (ark) appears only here and with Moses' ark ***of reeds***
  - ancient extrabiblical flood account *(Gilgamesh)* had a reed boat

Noah was to make a boat of reeds

QUESTION

- Noah must make his own vehicle of deliverance
  - Why?
  - Why doesn’t God build the boat?
  - Why doesn’t God provide the deliverance?
- Again, a symbolic understanding provides an answer

Symbolism of the Ark

- boat of <u>reeds</u>
  - weak fragile material *(1 Kgs 14:15; 18:21; Isa 36:6; 42:3; Ezek 29:6–7; Matt 12:20)*
- had to be <u>covered</u>
  - "*you will **<u>cover</u>** it inside and outside with **<u>covering</u>***"
    - idea of covering is repeated *(repetition for emphasis)*
    - Hebrew for "cover" *(kaphar)*
      - verb occurs only here and in context of atonement *(121 times)*
      - noun commonly used for a ransom
      - "inside and outside" commonly occurs with the tabernacle
      - original hearers would certainly make a tabernacle connection

Symbolism of the Ark

Putting it together

- vehicle for deliverance is characterized by weakness
- it is weakness that has to be covered to protect from judgment
- Noah must build it
  - for his benefit
    - (Hebrew: "*make to you*" > "*make for your benefit*")
  - submission to God's means of deliverance
  - recognition of weakness that needs to be covered

- Consistent with God's pattern of the tabernacle
  - focus on salvation
  - recognized weakness
  - need for atonement
  - God provides deliverance
  - submission to God's means of deliverance

HEBREW CONSTRUCTION

Make to you an ark of wood of gopher
reeds you will make the ark
and you will cover it inside and outside with covering

- This is the main statement
- Dimensions, floors, and “window” are added as background
- Therefore, the salvation symbolism is primary.
- This symbolism continues the themes of divine sovereignty and human responsibility

Additional Information

- Dimensions
  - reminiscent of the tabernacle court
- Window?
  - Hebrew > *tsahar* (only occurrence)
  - related to the verb "to shine"
  - Therefore, it is some provision of light, probably a window *(Gen 8:6)*
- Window & Door
  - window is emphasized (provision of light)
  - door is secondary (restriction of access)
- Floors?
  - "Below, second, and third you will make." ??

Narrative Comment

- God's speech is followed by an emphatic narrative statement:

And Noah did according to all that God commanded.
***Thus** he did!*

- Emphasis on the interaction between characters rather than the story.
- God speaks, Noah obeys
- God provides salvation, Noah responds

Note:
- Noah never speaks

GOD REMEMBERED NOAH

And God remembered Noah,
and all the wild animals
and all the domestic animals which were with him in the ark
And God caused a wind to pass over the earth
and the waters subsided.

GOD REMEMBERED NOAH

And God remembered Noah,
and all the wild animals
and all the domestic animals which were with him in the ark
And ***Elohim*** *caused a* ***ruakh*** *to pass over the earth*
and the waters subsided.

Alternative Translations

- And God caused a wind to pass over the earth
- And the Spirit of God passed over the earth

THE SPIRIT OF GOD

Arguments for "the Spirit of God"

- *ruakh Elohim*
  - combination appears only one other place in Genesis 1-11: Gen 1:2
  - similar context in both places
    - God begins to reverse the lifelessness of the watery deep
- "subsided"
  - Hebrew > *shakak*
    - means "to make quiet"
    - A wind blowing over the ocean causes turmoil, not quiet calm
- "pass over"
  - Commonly used to indicate "come upon"
  - "the Spirit of God came upon the earth and the waters quieted down"

(A blowing wind always uses another Hebrew word for "blow")

As in creation, the Spirit of God acts in re-creation!
As in all things, life comes from the Spirit of God!

THE BIRDS??

Odd Minutiae

- Why this insertion into the account? *(must be important)*
- Again, description contains a lot of symbolism
- Symbolism
  - Gilgamesh (flood story) refers to a raven and dove which are considered to be symbolic in that story
  - Ravens and doves are widely considered symbolic

THE BIRDS??

Analysis of the Episode

- The window
  - provided for light (refer to the instructions)
  - not glass or clear, but an opening with a cover
  - did not allow Noah to see below, only above
- Storyline
  - rain stops
  - Noah opens the window providing ***light*** and looks ***above***
  - Noah wonders if the flood (judgment) is over
  - The answer must come from other than his own perceptions
  - He looks for help from birds
    - In Genesis 1 birds are symbolic of interface between heaven and earth.
    - Throughout secular history, birds are symbolic of spiritual influences.

THE BIRDS??

Analysis of the Bird Symbolism

- Description of the birds
  - ***Not*** Noah sent out "a raven" and "a dove" . . .
  - ***but***, "Noah sent out "***the*** raven" and "***the*** dove."
  - The focus is not to two different birds, but the ***nature*** of the two birds
- Symbolism of the Raven
  - unclean *(Lev 11:15; Deut 14:14)* and depicts judgment *(e.g., Isa 34:11)*
- Symbolism of the Dove
  - sacrificial bird
  - heaven's approval of Jesus at his baptism
  - symbol of peace and rest *(Ps 55:6; Songs 2:14; Isa 60:8; Jer 48:28; Hosea 11:11)*
  - a universal symbol of peace in secular culture
- Raven > death
- Dove > life and peace

THE BIRDS??

Narrative Description

- Account of the dove is detailed, ***too*** detailed *(thus important)*

  *And **he sent out the dove** from with him . . .*
  And it returned to him to the ark. . .
  *And **he sent out his hand**.*
  *And **he took it**.*
  *And **he brought it to him** to the ark. . . .*

- Compare the overly detailed description of the account of the dove to the account of the raven

  He sent out the raven . . .

THE BIRDS??

Narrative Description

- Account of the dove is detailed, ***too*** detailed *(thus important)*

  And he sent out the dove ***from with him*** *. . .*
  And it returned ***to him*** *to the ark. . .*
  And he sent out ***his hand****.*
  And he took it.
  And he brought it ***to him*** *to the ark. . . .*

- An obvious focus on the Noah's relationship with the dove

THE BIRDS??

Narrative Description

- Other observations
  - The dove was looking for rest *(the raven for food)*
  - The dove returns with an **olive branch**
    - ancient universal symbol of peace
    - biblically connected to light, blessing & prosperity, salvation
      - Jesus will return to the Mount of Olives
      - Gentiles are grafted into an olive tree (Romans 11)
      - Olive oil is a source of light and associated with abundant blessing
    - biblically associated with suffering
      - beaten and crushed for the oil
      - Mount of Olives as a place of suffering
  - The dove returned with a ***torn*** olive leaf

THE BIRDS??

Narrative Description

- After 40 days (time of trial and testing)
- Noah wants to know if judgment is passed
- He looks for guidance from above
- He finds out the judgment is passed and new life has come
- Description includes numerous references to the number 7 (God's completed work of turning death into life)

- From a ***divine perspective***, life comes from the Spirit of God

  (God remembered Noah and the Spirit of God acted)
- From a ***human perspective***, guidance from above and leads to life and peace.